

do inhuman things. Although the killing of girl children may horrify our Digit family of readers, it's certainly not horrific enough to a very large part of India, because it still happens even in 2016!

If people don't think twice about ending a life, what makes us think they will have morality to not try and design babies? In a few decades we might find all rich kids looking like the film actors of today, and most of them are going to be male – because that's what Indian designer babies would probably be.

MAN'S BEST FRIEND

Most people in favour of genetic engineering will point out the man's best friend argument. Dogs are nothing more than genetically engineered wolves that humans bred into submission about 40,000 years ago. Humans and wolves would have been in direct competition during the ice age, and humans were probably killing off wolves that were confrontational, and allowing those that were more submissive to feast on the remains that humans left behind. It's assumed that humans might kill the ferocious adult wolves, but adopt orphaned wolf cubs.

By getting the tamer wolves used to eating cooked food, and breeding and keeping dogs, we achieved a massive feat of genetic engineering the wildness out of wolves, and created the dog species, of which there are so many variants now. However, taming dogs is one thing, what if someone wanted to breed a race of tame humans who would automatically be submissive to, say, white people... would we be as gung-ho about that idea as we are about dogs?

WHAT ABOUT CURES?

Ah, the double-edged blade that is medicine! Surely we can't be advocating that parents who have kids who are suffering from horrific diseases just shut up and bear it, and not be given an option to save their babies, right?

No, we're saying that editing of DNA itself is just the entrance of the rabbit hole. Scientists are sure to dive down the rabbit hole the first chance they get, because that's just what scientific curiosity is. If you could play god, you'd want to know what you could do, and test your skills in various ways. You're less likely



Domestic dogs, wild dogs and wolves all descended from a common ancestor

to sit back and think about the consequences of your actions in the long run.

Thus, in the short term you might save a life, but what about the long term consequences?

LIFE AND DEATH

It's a cycle, and for a reason. We live, we die. Imagine if you were born and never died? Maybe humans start dying at the age of 150 instead of, say, 75. That doubling of life actually means a lot to society and the world as a whole. The world has 7 billion people, and if all of them started living longer and reproducing for longer, we might double our population in no time. However, certain studies are of the opinion that the Earth can't accommodate more than 12 billion humans before all hell breaks loose. There just wouldn't be enough food to feed everyone, and faced with starvation and certain death, there's no telling what horrors 12 billion humans will inflict on one another.

STILL...

This is not to say that we should lose all humanity and allow people to die sooner for the greater good. Of course not. Neither do we want kids to die from curable

diseases. We're just asking about where the line in the sand is to be drawn when it comes to genetic engineering.

If editing DNA of living cells of suffering adults really does work, why would we not want that? For example, perhaps we could find a cure for Alzheimer's, or even Autism, which affect otherwise perfectly healthy people. A lot of neuroscience would come under this actually, and it's a valid question. Would we not want to cure Stephen Hawking of his Lou Gehrig's disease?

Of course we do, but what's next? Curing Robert of his baldness? Maybe Siddharth wants to be taller, Jayesh wants to be slimmer or Mithun wants to be prettier? Yes we're poking fun at ourselves, but the fact remains, there's always going to be people who want to modify themselves in some way in order to feel good about themselves, and it doesn't necessarily work – Michael Jackson was a prime example.

THE 'PERFECT' RACE

Now we get to the reason for our rather stark and evil-looking cover. It's not normal to want to take a baby and make it look like one of the most despised men in history... We did this because we believe